what the boss and Brian already had in place. He just concentrated on keeping the momentum going.

When you've had as much help with your game as I have, ever since the earliest days with Ridgeway Rovers, it's not right to talk about 'better coaching' or 'the best coach'. What I'd say for sure, though, is that Steve McClaren brought very different—and very much his own— qualities to the job. His technical ability, his organization, his communication on the training field, were all absolutely outstanding. He had a really open mind, too. If Steve heard about something new, he'd try it. If it worked, we'd use it. If not, nothing had been lost by having a go. When he arrived at Old Trafford in February 1999, he won the players' respect very quickly indeed.

United are a competitive team, even in training. Now and again, the manager will have to cut short a session because things are getting too heated. That's how it's always been at the club, from the youth team up. It's an edge: that desperation to win, never mind that it's only five-a-side games at training on a Friday morning. Steve took that on and he understood, as well, that our style was all about possession of the ball and made sure that was what training focused on. He made us laugh, too. In his fantasy moments, Steve McClaren is a very stylish player indeed: back then, he thought he was Glenn Hoddle, spraying his passes around the training fields at Carrington. We were already on a roll when Steve arrived but he kept the lads going all the way to the Champions League Final, even if it wasn't until the following season that he really made his own mark.

United have taken some criticism over the club's attitude to the FA Cup in recent seasons, particularly for not defending it in 2001 when we were asked to compete in FIFA's new World Club Championship out in Brazil. All I can say is that the manager along with every United player loves the competition, not least because it was so important the season we won the Treble. The third round match against Liverpool was one of the biggest games of that 1998/99 season. Liverpool scored through Michael Owen almost from the kick-off and then we battered them for the next eighty minutes without making a really good goal-scoring chance. The atmosphere was as good as I ever played in at Old Trafford. Maybe the fact that it was a cup game and Liverpool had more supporters there than they would for a Premiership match had something to do with it. Ole Gunnar Solskjaer came on as a sub. He always seemed to come on as a sub that season. And we equalized almost at once. Then Ole got the winner at the end and the place went berserk: for once the drama had been as intense as the rivalry.